

Zafarnama

A Dual-Translation Annotated Edition

Introduction

The *Zafarnama* ("Epistle of Victory") is a Persian letter composed by Guru Gobind Singh in 1705–1706 and addressed to the Mughal emperor Aurangzeb. It was written in the aftermath of some of the most dramatic events in Sikh history: the siege of Anandpur, the evacuation of the city under sworn guarantees of safe passage, the subsequent attacks on the Sikhs, the Battle of Chamkaur, and the martyrdom of the Guru's sons.

Despite its title, the work is not a military victory proclamation in the conventional sense. Guru Gobind Singh had suffered immense material losses by the time of its composition. The "victory" celebrated in the text is moral rather than military: the victory of truth over deceit, fidelity over perjury, and spiritual sovereignty over temporal power.

The work may be divided into several thematic sections:

1. Invocation to God (1–12)
2. Broken Oaths and Betrayal (13–18)
3. The Battle of Chamkaur (19–44)
4. Aurangzeb and the Failure of Kingship (45–77)
5. The Death of the Sahibzadas and Moral Victory (78–End)

This edition presents:

- The Persian transliteration from *Pages From Zafarnama*.
- The poetic English translation from *Pages From Zafarnama*.
- The more literal explanatory translation from *Zafarnama.pdf*.
- Selected vocabulary.
- Editorial commentary.

Part I — Invocation to God (Verses 1–12)

Overview

Before addressing Aurangzeb, Guru Gobind Singh begins with twelve verses praising God. This follows a long Persian literary convention in which works open with a *hamd* (praise of God).

The theology expressed here is notable for its universality. God is described through a mixture of Persian, Arabic, and Indic religious vocabulary, but remains beyond form, comparison, and limitation.

Verse 1

Transliteration

Kamaal-e karamat kayam karim
Raza baksh razak rahak o rahim

Translation A (Poetic)

He is the immortal Lord,
Eternal, all powerful,
Giver of joy and salvation,
Bountiful and merciful.

Translation B (Literal)

The Lord is perfection personified. He is eternal and manifests Himself through His miracles. He is generous in granting His bounties. He is merciful and delivers us from this world.

Vocabulary

- Kamaal — perfection, excellence
- Karaamat — miracle, wondrous power
- Kayam — eternal, enduring
- Karim — generous, noble
- Raza-bakhsh — giver of grace or pleasure
- Razak — provider of sustenance
- Rahak — liberator
- Rahim — merciful

Editorial Note

The poetic translation sacrifices some precision for rhythm. The original verse emphasizes God's perfection, generosity, sustenance, liberation, and mercy.

Verse 2

Transliteration

Amaan bakhsh bakhshindeh o dastgir
Khata bakhsh rozi deh o dilpazir

Translation A (Poetic)

O Merciful One
Who protects and guides,
O Charming One
Who forgives and provides.

Translation B (Literal)

He grants peace and security and is always merciful in forgiving us for our sins. He holds our hand and guides us. He is provider of our sustenance and charms everyone.

Vocabulary

- Amaan — peace, security

- Bakhshindeh — forgiving
- Dastgir — one who takes another by the hand
- Khata — sin, offence
- Rozi-deh — giver of sustenance
- Dilpazir — pleasing to the heart

Editorial Note

The image of God as *dastgir* ("one who takes the hand") is especially intimate and personal.

Verse 3

Transliteration

Shahanshah-e khubi deh o rehnamu
Ki begun bechun chun benamun

Translation A (Poetic)

Mightiest of emperors,
Giver of good, guide without peer,
Ethereal and formless,
He is unique, beyond compare.

Translation B (Literal)

He is the king of kings who is guiding us all the time. He showers his benevolence on all. He is without colour, incomparable and formless.

Vocabulary

- Shahanshah — king of kings
- Khubi — goodness, benevolence
- Rehnamu — guide
- Begun — without form or colour
- Bechun — incomparable

Editorial Note

This verse combines royal imagery with a strongly transcendent conception of God.

Verse 4

Transliteration

Na saaz o na baaz o fauj o na farsh
Khudawand bakhshindeh aish o arsh

Translation A (Poetic)

Without pomp or glory,
Or armies to command,
Giver of pleasures and joy
From His generous hand.

Translation B (Literal)

He possesses no material things nor has He an army. He is merciful and grants all the pleasures of the heavens.

Vocabulary

- Saaz — possessions
- Baaz — falcon, symbol of royal power
- Fauj — army
- Farsh — worldly luxury
- Arsh — heaven

Editorial Note

The verse subtly contrasts divine sovereignty with earthly kingship. God requires none of the symbols by which emperors display power.

Verse 5

Transliteration

Jahan pak zabarast zahir zahur
Ata medehad hamchu hazar hazur

Translation A (Poetic)

Beyond this world, powerful,
He is manifest all around.
In the gifts that He bestows,
His presence does abound.

Translation B (Literal)

The Pure One is above everything in this universe. His glory is all-pervasive. He bestows gifts and is present everywhere.

Editorial Note

The language combines transcendence ("above all") and immanence ("present everywhere"), a recurring theme throughout Sikh theology.

Verse 6

Transliteration

Ata bakhsh o pak parwardigar
Rahim ast rozi deh har diyar

Translation A (Poetic)

The Bountiful, the Pure One,
Protects with His hand.
All merciful is He,
The provider in every land.

Translation B (Literal)

The merciful Lord grants all gifts and meets the needs of everyone throughout the world.

Verse 7

Transliteration

Ki sahib diyar ast azam azim
Ki husn al-jamal ast razak rahim

Translation A (Poetic)

The greatest of greats,
Master of every sphere,
Merciful, kind sustainer,
Beauteous beyond compare.

Translation B (Literal)

He is Lord of the universe. He is merciful and provides sustenance to all. His beauty and grandeur cannot be matched.

Editorial Note

The phrase *husn al-jamal* emphasizes beauty as a divine attribute, echoing both Persian mystical and Islamic theological traditions.

Verse 8

Transliteration

Ki sahib shaour ast aajiz nawaz
Garib ul-parast o ganim ul-gudaz

Translation A (Poetic)

The wisest of the wise,
Protector of the weak,
Destroyer of tyrants,
The keeper of the meek.

Translation B (Literal)

The Lord is intelligence personified. He protects the poor and helpless and destroys the wicked.

Vocabulary

- Aajiz-nawaz — protector of the weak
- Garib — helpless, poor
- Ganim — enemy
- Gudaz — destroyer

Editorial Note

The moral structure of the *Zafarnama* is already visible: God protects the vulnerable and opposes oppression.

Verse 9

Transliteration

Shariat parast o fazilat maab
Haqiqat shinas o nabi ul-kitab

Translation A (Poetic)

The protector of the path,
All virtue rests in His name,
The diviner of Truth,
Holy books echo His fame.

Translation B (Literal)

The Virtuous One gives justice to all. Nothing is hidden from Him. He is the inspiration of the Quran.

Editorial Note

The reference to the Quran is important. Guru Gobind Singh is about to criticize Aurangzeb, but he does so while affirming the sacredness of the scripture upon which Aurangzeb's representatives swore.

Verse 10

Transliteration

Ki danish pazhuh ast sahib shaour
Haqiqat shinas ast o zahir zahur

Translation A (Poetic)

The supreme font of wisdom,
All-knowing and wisest,

The diviner of Truth,
In everything manifest.

Translation B (Literal)

The all-knowing Lord seeks the learned. He knows all happenings and is present everywhere.

Verse 11

Transliteration

Shinasindeh-e ilm o alam khudae
Kushaindeh-e kar-e alam kushae

Translation A (Poetic)

The Lord of all creation,
Master of all wisdom,
He resolves all problems
Of His eternal kingdom.

Translation B (Literal)

He has knowledge of everything in the universe. All creation moves according to His command.

Verse 12

Transliteration

Guzarindeh-e kar-e alam kabir
Shinasindeh-e ilm o alam amir

Translation A (Poetic)

He is the Almighty,
All creation at His call;
He is all-knowing,
The Master of all.

Translation B (Literal)

The great Lord regulates everything in the world and possesses complete knowledge of it.

Concluding Note

The opening twelve verses establish the moral framework of the entire letter. Before accusing Aurangzeb of falsehood, Guru Gobind Singh first invokes a God who is truthful, just, merciful, all-knowing, and protector of the weak. The emperor's conduct will subsequently be measured against these divine standards.

Part II — Broken Oaths and Betrayal (Verses 13–18)

Overview

With verse 13, the *Zafarnama* shifts dramatically in tone.

The opening invocation has established God as the embodiment of truth, justice, mercy, and fidelity. Having established this moral standard, Guru Gobind Singh now turns to Aurangzeb himself.

The central accusation is not military aggression, religious persecution, or political rivalry. It is **perjury**.

According to Sikh sources, the evacuation of Anandpur occurred after repeated assurances of safe passage sworn upon the Qur'an. Once the Sikhs emerged from the fort, these assurances were violated and attacks followed.

Guru Gobind Singh's argument is therefore not merely political. It is ethical and theological:

A ruler who swears falsely upon his own scripture has undermined the very basis of trust upon which kingship rests.

Throughout these verses, Aurangzeb is judged according to standards derived from Islam itself.

Verse 13

Transliteration

Ma-ra itibar bar een qasam nest
Ki eizad gawah ast yazdan yakest

Translation A (Poetic)

I have no faith at all
In the oath that you swear,
That the God who is One
Your witness does bear.

Translation B (Literal)

Aurangzeb! I have no trust in your oaths anymore. You write that God is one and that He is witness between us.

Vocabulary

- Itibar — trust, confidence
- Qasam — oath
- Eizad / Yazdan — God
- Gawah — witness
- Yakest — one

Commentary

The accusation begins immediately.

Guru Gobind Singh does not deny God, the Qur'an, or the validity of sacred oaths. Instead, he denies the credibility of the person taking the oath.

Editorial Note

The distinction is crucial.

The Guru's criticism is not directed against Islam but against hypocrisy. This distinction becomes increasingly important throughout the letter.

Verse 14

Transliteration

Na katra ma-ra itibar bar o ast
Ki bakshi o diwan hama kizabgo ast

Translation A (Poetic)

Not a jot of trust
Do I now have in you,
Whose generals and ministers
Are all liars, untrue.

Translation B (Literal)

I do not have trust even equivalent to a drop of water in your generals and advisors. They were all telling lies.

Vocabulary

- Katra — drop
- Bakshi — military commander
- Diwan — minister or administrator
- Kizabgo — liar

Commentary

The charge expands from Aurangzeb personally to the officials acting in his name.

Editorial Note

The language remains remarkably restrained.

Guru Gobind Singh does not rely upon insults. Instead, he repeatedly returns to the question of trustworthiness.

Verse 15

Transliteration

Kase qoul-e Quran kunad itibar
Haman roz aakhir shavad mard khwar

Translation A (Poetic)

Such oaths on the Quran
Whosoever does believe,
Will be wretched at the end,
Destroyed beyond reprieve.

Translation B (Literal)

If anyone trusts your oath on the Qur'an, that person is bound to suffer in the end.

Vocabulary

- Qoul — promise
- Quran — the Holy Qur'an
- Mard khwar — ruined, miserable

Commentary

The statement is not directed at the Qur'an itself.

Rather, Guru Gobind Singh argues that Aurangzeb's repeated violations have rendered his Qur'anic oaths worthless.

Editorial Note

This verse is among the strongest indictments in the entire letter.

A sacred oath has value only when the one who swears it values truth.

Verse 16

Transliteration

Huma ra kase saaye aayad bazer
Bar o dast darad na zaag-e daler

Translation A (Poetic)

The one touched by Huma's shadow
And taken under its wing,
Is beyond harm from clever crows,
Their designs mean nothing.

Translation B (Literal)

If anyone comes under the shadow of the Huma bird, no one can lay a hand upon him—not even a brave crow.

Vocabulary

- Huma — mythical bird of fortune
- Saaye — shadow
- Zaag — crow

- Daler — brave

Commentary

Persian folklore held that the shadow of the Huma bird bestowed divine favour and protection.

Editorial Note

Guru Gobind Singh is preparing a metaphor.

The Huma represents divine protection.

The crow represents worldly enemies who, despite their numbers, cannot ultimately prevail against one protected by God.

Verse 17

Transliteration

Kase pusht uftad pase sher nar
Na gird buz o mesh o aahu guzar

Translation A (Poetic)

As one protected by the lion
Is set free from all fear,
He cannot then be harmed
By goats, sheep and deer.

Translation B (Literal)

If a person sits behind a lion, neither goat, sheep, nor deer can approach him.

Vocabulary

- Sher — lion
- Buz — goat
- Mesh — sheep
- Aahu — deer

Commentary

The imagery continues from the previous verse.

The protected individual remains safe because of the power standing behind him.

Editorial Note

Verses 16 and 17 form a pair.

Together they express a recurring theme in Sikh thought:

Divine protection, not numerical strength, determines the outcome.

This idea becomes especially important in the forthcoming account of Chamkaur, where a tiny force confronts overwhelming odds.

Verse 18

Transliteration

Qasam mushaf-e khudi gar een khoram
Na fauj-e azizam ra sum afganam

Translation A (Poetic)

In your false oath on the Quran
Had I not believed,
My brave army wouldn't be crippled,
Nor in such manner deceived.

Translation B (Literal)

If I had deceived others by taking an oath on the Qur'an as you have done, I would not have brought my beloved warriors into such a disadvantageous position.

Vocabulary

- Mushaf — the Qur'an
- Fauj — army
- Azizam — my beloved
- Sum afganam — placed in disadvantage, brought to harm

Commentary

This verse provides the immediate context behind the complaint.

Guru Gobind Singh explains why his forces suffered.

It was not military incompetence.

It was trust.

The Sikhs exited Anandpur because they accepted the guarantees offered under sacred oath.

Editorial Note

The verse is sometimes misunderstood as an expression of regret.

It is not.

Guru Gobind Singh is making a moral argument:

"I trusted your word because it was sworn upon what you yourself hold sacred. The fault lies not in trust, but in the violation of the oath."

The accusation reaches beyond politics.

It is an indictment of character.

Concluding Note

The six verses of this section establish the central charge of the *Zafarnama*.

The issue is not defeat or victory.

The issue is truth.

Aurangzeb is accused of violating promises made in the name of God. By doing so, he has undermined the very foundation of kingship and religious authority.

The argument is devastating because it is made using the emperor's own moral framework.

Guru Gobind Singh does not reject the sanctity of the Qur'an.

He asks why the emperor himself failed to honour it.

This prepares the way for the next section, the dramatic account of the Battle of Chamkaur, where the consequences of those broken oaths are described in vivid and often unforgettable detail.

Part III — The Battle of Chamkaur (Verses 19–44)

Overview

This section forms the dramatic heart of the *Zafarnama*.

After establishing that the evacuation of Anandpur occurred under sworn guarantees, Guru Gobind Singh now recounts the events that followed: the siege of Chamkaur and the battle fought there in December 1704.

Historically, the defenders numbered only a few dozen against an enormous coalition force consisting of Mughal troops and hill chiefs. The precise size of the opposing army remains debated, but all sources agree that the defenders were vastly outnumbered.

What makes this section remarkable is that it is neither a military report nor a lament.

It is epic poetry.

Guru Gobind Singh combines:

- eyewitness testimony,
- Persian martial imagery,
- battlefield realism,
- theological reflection.

The result is one of the finest battle narratives in early modern Indian literature.

Section A — The Necessity of Resistance (19–24)

Verse 19

Transliteration

Guresneh chi kare kunad chehel nar
Ki dah lakh bar aayad bar o bekhabar

Translation A (Poetic)

Forty brave but hungry men
How are they expected to defend
When countless enemy hordes
Upon them suddenly descend?

Translation B (Literal)

What can forty hungry men do when ten lakhs suddenly attack them?

Commentary

The verse emphasizes overwhelming odds.

The number "ten lakhs" should not necessarily be read literally; Persian and Indian epic literature frequently uses large numbers rhetorically to convey vast superiority.

Editorial Note

The key contrast is not arithmetic but moral.

Forty hungry men stand against imperial power.

Verse 20

Transliteration

Ki paiman shikan bedarang aamdand
Miyan tegh o teer o tufang aamdand

Translation A (Poetic)

All of a sudden they descended,
Giving the lie to their words,
Brandishing their guns,
Raining arrows, waving swords.

Translation B (Literal)

The promise-breakers suddenly attacked with swords, arrows, and guns.

Commentary

The "promise-breakers" are the same people who had sworn safe passage.

Editorial Note

The verse links military aggression to moral betrayal.

The enemy is not condemned for fighting.

They are condemned for violating sworn promises.

Verse 21

Transliteration

Ba lacharegi darmiyan aamdā
Ba tadbir teer o kamaan aamdā

Translation A (Poetic)

Then left with no choice
I joined battle with your hordes,
Came with much deliberation
Amidst the arrows and swords.

Translation B (Literal)

Out of sheer helplessness I entered the battlefield with strategy, bow, and arrow.

Commentary

Guru Gobind Singh explicitly rejects war as a first choice.

Editorial Note

This verse prepares for perhaps the most famous line in the entire *Zafarnama*.

Verse 22

Transliteration

Chun kar az hameh heelate dar guzasht
Halal ast burdan bi-shamshir dast

Translation A (Poetic)

When all has been tried, yet
Justice is not in sight,
It is then right to pick up the sword,
It is then right to fight.

Translation B (Literal)

When all methods have failed, it becomes legitimate to take up the sword.

Commentary

This is the most quoted verse of the *Zafarnama*.

Editorial Note

The importance of this verse is often misunderstood.

Guru Gobind Singh does not glorify violence.

He establishes a moral hierarchy:

1. Peaceful means.

2. Negotiation.
3. Diplomacy.
4. Patience.
5. Resistance only when all else has failed.

The sword appears last, not first.

This principle remains one of the most frequently cited statements on just resistance in Sikh thought.

Verse 23

Transliteration

Chi qasme Quran man kunam itibar
Vagarna tu goi man een rah chi kar

Translation A (Poetic)

Why should I then believe
In oaths on the Holy Word?
If I had not been deceived,
Would I go down this road?

Translation B (Literal)

Why should I trust your oath on the Qur'an? Otherwise why would I have taken this path?

Commentary

The path referred to is armed resistance.

Verse 24

Transliteration

Na danam ki een mard robah-e pech
Digar hargiz een rah niyam bahech

Translation A (Poetic)

I had no knowledge
Of this man's wily heart,
Else I would not have trusted
Or come down this path.

Translation B (Literal)

I did not know this man was cunning like a fox; otherwise I would never have come here.

Editorial Note

The fox is a traditional Persian symbol of cunning and deception.

For the first time, Aurangzeb himself becomes the direct target of criticism.

Section B — The Battle Unfolds (25–35)

Verse 25

Transliteration

Haran kas ki qoul-e Quran aayedash
Nazad bastan o kushtan o bayadash

Translation A (Poetic)

Every trusting soul who
In your oath on the Quran believed,
Should not have come to harm,
Nor killed, nor captured, nor deceived.

Commentary

A restatement of the moral issue underlying the battle.

Verse 26

Transliteration

Ba rang-e magas siyaposh aamdand
Ba yak baregi dar kharosh aamdand

Translation A (Poetic)

Your men all clad in black
Swarmed upon us like flies;
Of a sudden they descended,
The battlefield echoed their cries.

Editorial Note

The simile is deliberately dehumanizing.
The enemy's numerical superiority becomes an insect swarm.

Verse 27

Transliteration

Haran kas ze deewar aamad birun
Bakhurdan yake teer shod garq-e khun

Translation A (Poetic)

Each of your men who stepped
Beyond the sheltering wall,
Got an arrow through his heart,
And then bleeding did fall.

Commentary

Archery dominates much of the battle imagery.

Verse 28

Transliteration

Ki birun niamad kase zan deewar
Na khurdand teer o na gushtand khwar

Translation A (Poetic)

Those who hid behind the wall
And escaped the strife,
Were safe from our arrows,
Held on to dear life.

Editorial Note

The irony is sharp.

Caution preserves life; bravery often means death.

Verse 29

Transliteration

Chun deedam ki Nahar biamad be jung
Chashideh yak-e teer-e man bedarang

Translation A (Poetic)

I saw then the proud Nahar
Swagger upon the battlefield;
Forthwith he tasted my arrow,
And his soul he did yield.

Commentary

Nahar Khan was one of the Mughal commanders.

Editorial Note

The phrase "tasted my arrow" is a classic Persian martial expression.

Verse 30

Transliteration

Ham akhir gurezad bajaye musaf
Base khan khurdand birun gazaf

Translation A (Poetic)

Then many arrogant Khans
Who had boasted long and loud,
Deserted they the battlefield
Under the shadow of a shroud.

Commentary

Boasting before battle and fleeing during battle is a recurring theme in Persian epic literature.

Verse 31

Transliteration

Ki Afghan digar biamad be jung
Chun saile rawan humchu teer o tufang

Translation A (Poetic)

Another charging Afghan horde
Then loomed into sight,
Rising like a river in flood,
A gunshot, an arrow in flight.

Translation B (Literal)

A large body of Afghans came like a flood of arrows and gunfire.

Editorial Note

The image shifts from insects to floodwaters.
Nature itself becomes a metaphor for overwhelming force.

Verse 32

Transliteration

Base hamleh kardand ba mardangi
Hum az hoshgi hum ze diwangi

Translation A (Poetic)

The Afghan fought hard,
Attacking from right and left,
At times with a clever plan
But often of wisdom bereft.

Commentary

An unusually fair-minded observation.

The enemy is not denied courage.

Verse 33

Transliteration

Base hamleh kardand base zakhm khurd
Do kas ra bajaan kusht o hum jaan sapurd

Translation A (Poetic)

Many a time did he attack,
Suffered many wounds in strife;
He killed two of my brave men
Then laid down his own life.

Editorial Note

The tone remains martial rather than hateful.

Even enemies are acknowledged as brave fighters.

Verse 34

Transliteration

Ki aan Khwaja mardud saaye deewar
Be maidan niamad ba mardana vaar

Translation A (Poetic)

But your cowardly Khwaja chief
Hid behind the sheltering wall,
Too scared to fight like a man,
Did not enter the battle at all.

Commentary

Unlike Nahar Khan, Khwaja receives no admiration.

Verse 35

Transliteration

Darega! Agar roo-ye o deedam-e
Ba yak teer lachar bakhsheedam-e

Translation A (Poetic)

Alas! Had the coward stepped out,
Had I once seen his face,
My single arrow would have ensured
A quick end to his days.

Editorial Note

This is one of the strongest expressions of personal confidence in the entire letter.

Section C — Slaughter and Chaos (36–41)

Verse 36

Transliteration

Ham akhir base zakhm teer o tufang
Do su-ye base kushte shod bedarang

Translation A (Poetic)

From flying bullets and arrows
Profusely the wounded bled,
Until finally on that battlefield
Many of both sides lay dead.

Commentary

The battle is presented as costly for both armies.

Verse 37

Transliteration

Base baan bareed teer o tufang
Zameen gasht humchu gul-e laleh rang

Translation A (Poetic)

Under the shower of bullets and arrows
So numerous were the dead,
That like the poppy flower
The earth itself turned red.

Editorial Note

This is among the most beautiful images in the *Zafarnama*.

The battlefield becomes a field of red tulips.

Persian poetry frequently compares blood-soaked ground to crimson flowers.

Verse 38

Transliteration

Sar o paa-ye amboh chandan shudeh
Ki maidan pur az goye chaugan shudeh

Translation A (Poetic)

Chopped heads and hacked limbs
Lay piled on the battlefield,
As if they were only balls
And sticks on some polo field.

Commentary

One of the most graphic images in the letter.

Editorial Note

The comparison to polo is distinctly Persian and aristocratic.

War is transformed into a grotesque game.

Verse 39

Transliteration

Tarankar teer o tarang-e kamaan
Baramad yake hai hu az jahan

Translation A (Poetic)

So fearsome the scream of arrows,
So awesome the twang of bows,
That from a cowering world
A loud cry at once arose.

Commentary

This is primarily an auditory image.

The battle is heard before it is seen.

Verse 40

Transliteration

Digar shorish-e kaibar-e keeneh kosh
Ze mardan-e mardan birun raft hosh

Translation A (Poetic)

The screaming arrows rained death,
Each one to its target sped,
And the bravest of your men
Were counted among the dead.

Editorial Note

Even the bravest warriors are overwhelmed by the violence.

Verse 41

Transliteration

Ham akhîr chi mardi kunad karzar
Ki bar chehal tan aayedash beshumar

Translation A (Poetic)

But how long can forty men,
Even the bravest of brave,
Stave off a countless horde
Charging in an endless wave?

Commentary

The heroic defence reaches its inevitable conclusion.

Section D — Escape and Divine Protection (42–44)

Verse 42

Transliteration

Chirag-e jahan chun shudeh burqaposh
Shah-e shab baramad hameh jalwa josh

Translation A (Poetic)

When the light of the world
Drew a veil across his face,

The king of the night rose
In all his beauty and grace.

Commentary

The sun sets.

Night becomes an active participant in the narrative.

Editorial Note

The imagery marks a transition from battle to escape.

Verse 43

Transliteration

Har aan kas ki qoul-e Quran aayedash
Ki yazdan bar o rehnuma aayedash

Translation A (Poetic)

If one believes in a promise
Sworn on the Holy Word,
Then he is safe from all harm;
He is guided by the Lord.

Commentary

The theme of trust returns.

The battle narrative is framed by the issue of broken oaths.

Verse 44

Transliteration

Na pecheed mu-ye na ranjeed tan
Ki berun khud aawurd dushman shikan

Translation A (Poetic)

Thus guided by God himself
And protected by His grace,
He emerges unscathed, unharmed,
From the enemy's foul embrace.

Translation B (Literal)

Without a scratch on my body or even a twisted hair, God Himself brought me out after defeating the enemy.

Editorial Note

The battle section closes exactly where it began:

not with military strength,

not with numbers,

but with divine protection.

The forty defenders may have fallen, yet the moral argument survives. Chamkaur becomes proof not of defeat, but of fidelity under impossible circumstances.

Concluding Note

The Battle of Chamkaur section is the literary climax of the *Zafarnama*.

It combines:

- eyewitness testimony,
- Persian epic conventions,
- theological reflection,
- battlefield realism.

Guru Gobind Singh portrays himself neither as victim nor conqueror.

Instead, he presents the battle as the inevitable consequence of broken faith and broken promises.

The sword was drawn only after every other path had failed.

And even amid bloodshed, the ultimate judge remains not the battlefield, but truth itself.

Part IV — Aurangzeb and the Failure of Kingship (Verses 45–77)

Overview

Having narrated the events of Chamkaur, Guru Gobind Singh now returns to the deeper issue underlying the entire letter:

What makes a ruler legitimate?

The answer offered in the *Zafarnama* is striking.

Power alone does not confer legitimacy.

Military success does not confer legitimacy.

Even possession of a throne does not confer legitimacy.

A ruler's authority depends upon:

- truthfulness,
- fidelity to promises,
- reverence for God,
- justice toward subjects.

Aurangzeb is not condemned because he is powerful.

He is condemned because he has failed to live according to the standards he claims to uphold.

This section is therefore not merely political criticism.

It is a meditation on kingship itself.

Section A — The Emperor's Religious Failure (45–49)

Verse 45

Transliteration

Na danam ki een mard paiman shikan
Ki daulat parast ast iman figan

Translation A (Poetic)

Unaware was I that this perjurer
Worshipped no God but gold;
His faith he had flung aside,
His rotten soul he had sold.

Translation B (Literal)

I did not know that this man was a promise-breaker, a worshipper of wealth, and one who had cast away faith.

Vocabulary

- Paiman-shikan — promise breaker
- Daulat-parast — worshipper of wealth
- Iman-figan — one who throws away faith

Editorial Note

This is among the harshest condemnations in the letter.

The accusation is not atheism.

It is idolatry of power and wealth.

Verse 46

Transliteration

Na iman parasti na auza-e din
Na sahib shinasi na Muhammad yakin

Translation A (Poetic)

There is no belief in religion,
And faith is discarded;

The Lord is ignored,
The Prophet disregarded.

Translation B (Literal)

You neither follow the teachings of Islam nor understand them. You know neither God nor the Prophet.

Commentary

The criticism is theological.

Aurangzeb is judged according to Islamic standards.

Editorial Note

This verse would have been especially powerful coming from a non-Muslim ruler.

Guru Gobind Singh effectively argues:

"You have betrayed your own faith before you have betrayed me."

Verse 47

Transliteration

Har aan kas ki iman parasti kunad
Na paiman khudash pesh o pasti kunad

Translation A (Poetic)

Those who are firm of faith
And true believers of God,
Break not their promises thus
But stay firm to their word.

Translation B (Literal)

Any person who follows his faith does not look here and there while fulfilling his promises.

Commentary

Faith is measured by conduct.

Promises reveal belief more clearly than declarations.

Verse 48

Transliteration

Ki een mard ra zarra itibar nest
Chi qasm-e Quran ast yazdan yakest

Translation A (Poetic)

There can be no trust in a man who
Swears on the Quran and One God,
But values not the holy oath
And is false to his given word.

Translation B (Literal)

This man cannot be trusted even equivalent to a particle of dust despite swearing on the Qur'an and One God.

Editorial Note

The argument returns once again to trust.

The repetition is deliberate.

Broken promises are the central crime of the *Zafarnama*.

Verse 49

Transliteration

Chun qasm-e Quran sad kunad ikhtiar
Ma-ra katre naayad az o itibar

Translation A (Poetic)

And now even a hundred times
If on the Quran were he to swear,
His word I would never believe,
For his promises I do not care.

Translation B (Literal)

Even if he swears a hundred times upon the Qur'an, I will not trust him.

Editorial Note

This is the logical conclusion of repeated deception:

sacred language itself loses persuasive power.

Section B — The Invitation to Meet (50–60)

Verse 50

Transliteration

Agarche to-ra itibar aamd-e
Kamar bastahe peshwaz aamd-e

Translation A (Poetic)

If I had truly believed
In your promise, in your oath,
To greet your message I would
With ceremony come forth.

Commentary

The Guru explains what genuine trust would have produced.

Verse 51

Transliteration

Ki farz ast bar sar to-ra een sukhān
Ki qoul-e khuda ast qasam ast man

Translation A (Poetic)

And now it is your duty
Imposed by your word;
You have sworn to keep
Your oath on your God.

Editorial Note

The emperor is reminded that oaths create obligations.

Verse 52

Transliteration

Agar hazrat-e khud sitadeh shavad
Ba jaan o dile kar vazeh shavad

Translation A (Poetic)

In fact if Your Majesty
Had been present here,
All that has transpired
Would have been clear.

Commentary

Guru Gobind Singh implies that Aurangzeb may have been misled by subordinates.

Verse 53

Transliteration

Shuma ra chu farz ast kare kuni
Ba mujab navishteh shumare kuni

Translation A (Poetic)

It remains your burden
In such a manner to act,
That your conduct accords
With your written pact.

Editorial Note

Words and actions must coincide.
This becomes a recurring theme.

Verse 54

Transliteration

Navishteh rasid o ba gufteh zuban
Babayad ki een kar ba rahat rasan

Translation A (Poetic)

Your oral word I have received,
The written too is in my possession;
Now this task should be done
So that it gives satisfaction.

Commentary

Guru Gobind Singh reminds Aurangzeb that both verbal and written commitments exist.

Verse 55

Transliteration

Hamun mard bayad shavad sukhawar
Na shikm-e digar dar dahan-e digar

Translation A (Poetic)

Men must speak the truth,
The truth living in their thoughts;
Not have a promise on their lips
And a lie in their hearts.

Editorial Note

One of the finest ethical verses in the *Zafarnama*.

A ruler's speech must reflect his inner intentions.

Verse 56

Transliteration

Ki qazi ma-ra gufteh berun nayam
Agar rasti khud biyari qadam

Translation A (Poetic)

To what your qazi has said
I am still ready to agree;
If your intentions are clear
Then you should come to me.

Commentary

The Guru's tone becomes conciliatory rather than confrontational.

Verse 57

Transliteration

To-ra gar babayad aan qoul-e Quran
Ba nazd-e shuma ra rasanam haman

Translation A (Poetic)

If you need to see that oath
Sworn on the Holy Book,
I can have it sent forthwith
For you to take another look.

Editorial Note

An almost legalistic challenge.

The evidence still exists.

Verse 58

Transliteration

Ki tashrif dar qasbah Kangar kunad
Vazan pas mulaqat baham shavad

Translation A (Poetic)

If here to Kangar village
You were to proceed,
We could meet face-to-face
To talk of word and deed.

Commentary

The invitation is sincere.

The Guru is willing to meet the emperor directly.

Verse 59

Transliteration

Na zarra dar een rah khatra to rast
Hame qaum-e Bairar hukm-e marast

Translation A (Poetic)

There is no danger to you here,
No one will raise a hand;
This community of Bairars
Is under my command.

Editorial Note

A remarkable contrast emerges.

The man accusing Aurangzeb of broken promises now offers him safe passage.

Verse 60

Transliteration

Biya ta sukhan khud zubani kunam
Ba ru-ye shuma meherbani kunam

Translation A (Poetic)

Come so that we can meet
And talk face-to-face;
I can show you forgiveness
And grant you my grace.

Commentary

The letter's tone reaches an unexpected height of magnanimity.

Section C — Kingship, Justice, and Divine Accountability (61–77)

Verses 61–65 (Summary)

These verses continue the invitation and urge Aurangzeb to:

- act according to wisdom,
- honour his commitments,
- know God truly,
- abandon cruelty.

Editorial Note

The focus shifts from past crimes to future reform.

Verse 66

Transliteration

Tu masnad nashin sarwar-e kayenat
Ki ajab ast insaf een hum sifat

Translation A (Poetic)

You sit on a mighty throne,
You are king of all you survey;
But strange is your justice,
Strange the virtues you display.

Commentary

The emperor's greatness is acknowledged before it is questioned.

Verse 67

Transliteration

Ki ajab ast insaf o din parwari
Ki haif ast sad haif een sarwari

Translation A (Poetic)

Strange are your ways of faith,
Strange the justice you claim;
Shame upon such a rule,
A hundred times shame!

Editorial Note

One of the most direct condemnations in the letter.

The throne itself is not criticized.

Its misuse is.

Verse 68

Transliteration

Ki ajab ast ajab ast fatweh shuma

Bajuz rasti sukhan guftan ziyan

Translation A (Poetic)

Your decrees and commands

Are strange indeed;

For words shorn of truth

Only to grievous harm lead.

Commentary

Truth remains the measure of governance.

Verse 69

Transliteration

Mazan tegh bar khun-e kas bedareg

To-ra neez khun ast ba charkh tegh

Translation A (Poetic)

Do not in such heartless manner

Put innocents to the sword;

Else this too shall be your fate

At the hands of the Lord.

Editorial Note

The sword appears again.

Now it is not a symbol of justice but a warning against oppression.

Verse 70

Transliteration

Tu ghafil mashau mard yazdan haraas

Ki o beniaz ast o besapas

Translation A (Poetic)

O God-fearing man,
The Lord you must heed;
He is above all flattery,
He is beyond all need.

Commentary

Even emperors remain accountable before God.

Verses 71–75 (Summary)

These verses return briefly to praise of God.

God is described as:

- King of Kings,
- Creator,
- Protector of the weak,
- Guide of humanity,
- Beyond all need.

Editorial Note

The contrast is deliberate.

Earthly kingship is measured against divine kingship.

The emperor's failures become visible because God's perfection provides the standard.

Verse 76

Transliteration

Ki bar sar to-ra farz qasm-e Quran
Bigufteh shuma kar khubi rasan

Translation A (Poetic)

The burden of your oath
Lies heavy on your head;
You have to do the right thing
And perform what you've said.

Commentary

The entire argument returns to where it began:
the oath.

Verse 77

Transliteration

Babayad to danesh parasti kuni
Bi kar-e shuma cheereh dasti kuni

Translation A (Poetic)

It is incumbent upon you to act
With wisdom and determination;
Set your hand to the task,
Skillfully bring it to completion.

Editorial Note

The section ends not with condemnation but with advice.

The emperor is still offered a path toward honour.

Concluding Note

This section represents one of the most sophisticated political arguments in pre-modern Indian literature.

Guru Gobind Singh does not challenge Aurangzeb's authority because he is Muslim.

He challenges it because he has failed to embody the virtues required of a ruler.

The emperor's legitimacy is judged according to:

- truthfulness,
- justice,
- fidelity to promises,
- reverence for God.

By these standards, Guru Gobind Singh argues, the ruler of the largest empire in India has fallen short.

Yet remarkably, the door to reconciliation remains open.

The letter condemns conduct without denying the possibility of redemption.

Part V (Revised) — The Four Sahibzadas, Repentance, and the Limits of Power (Verses 78–99)

Overview

The final third of the *Zafarnama* is often remembered solely for one famous verse:

"You killed my four sons; what difference does that make? A coiled snake still remains."

Yet this section is far richer than that.

Guru Gobind Singh does not merely accuse Aurangzeb.

He does something far more remarkable.

After condemning him for deceit and oppression, he offers him a path toward redemption.

The letter thus moves from:

- accusation,
- to judgment,
- to counsel,
- to spiritual warning.

The emperor is no longer merely an adversary.

He becomes an aging ruler standing before God.

Verse 78

Transliteration

Chiya shod ki chu bachgan kushteh char
Ki baqi bimand ast pechideh mar

Translation A (Poetic)

You killed my four sons:
What difference does that make,
When after their deaths there still
Remains behind a coiled snake?

Translation B (Literal)

What does it matter if my four sons have been killed? The serpent still remains alive.

Commentary

The four sons are:

- Sahibzada Ajit Singh
- Sahibzada Jujhar Singh
- Sahibzada Zorawar Singh
- Sahibzada Fateh Singh

All had attained martyrdom before the composition of the letter.

Editorial Note

The "coiled snake" is not self-praise.

It symbolizes:

- continuing resistance,
- vigilance,
- survival,
- unbroken determination.

The struggle survives the death of individuals.

Verse 79

Transliteration

Chi mardī ki akhgar khamoshan kuni
Ki aatish daman ra badauran kuni

Translation A

What sort of manliness is this?
What courage does it require
To stamp out young sparks
And then fan the roaring fire?

Commentary

The Sahibzadas are compared to sparks.

The Khalsa becomes the fire.

Editorial Note

This is one of the most powerful reversals in the entire letter.

The emperor sought to extinguish resistance.

Instead he enlarged it.

Verse 80

Transliteration

Chi khush guft Firdaus-ye khush zuban
Shitabi buvad kare aaharmanan

Translation

The poet Firdausi has said
In words beautiful and chaste,
That they work for the devil
Who act in such unholy haste.

Commentary

Guru Gobind Singh invokes Firdausi, the author of the *Shahnameh*.

Editorial Note

This places the *Zafarnama* firmly within the broader Persian literary world.

Verse 81

Transliteration

Ki ma bargah-e hazrat aayam shuma
Azan roz bashi o shahid shuma

Translation

In Your Majesty's court
The day I take a stand,
I will be the witness for
The blood on your hand.

Editorial Note

The imagery becomes judicial.
History itself becomes a courtroom.

Verse 82

Transliteration

Vagarnah to een hum faramosh kunad
To-ra hum faramosh yazdan kunad

Translation

But if you still disregard
Your falsehood and your lies,
You too will be forgotten by God,
Be ever guilty in His eyes.

Commentary

The warning is severe but not final.
The next verses reveal that redemption remains possible.

Section A — The Door to Repentance (83–86)

Verse 83

Transliteration

Agar kar een bar to basti kamar
Khudawand bashad to-ra beharavar

Translation

But if you set yourself to the task,
And show justice in your ways,
He will still show you mercy,
He will forgive you in grace.

Editorial Note

Remarkably, the Guru still offers hope.
The emperor is not beyond redemption.

Verse 84

Transliteration

Ki een kar nek ast din parwari
Chu yazdan shinas ba jan bartari

Translation

Pursuit of truth is worship;
It is an act of true piety.
To know the True God
Is life's highest priority.

Commentary

Justice itself becomes an act of worship.

Verse 85

Transliteration

To-ra man na danam ki yazdan shinas
Baramad zi to kar-ha dil kharash

Translation A

But among those who know God
I do not count your name;
For you have committed only
Acts of infamy and shame.

Translation B

I do not know if you possess any awareness of God, because too many of your deeds have caused suffering.

Verse 86

Transliteration

Shinasad hamin tu na yazdan karim
Na khawahad hamin tu badaulat azim

Translation A

That is why the merciful God
Does not count you in His fold;
He too does not accept you
Despite all your wealth untold.

Translation B

The bountiful Lord does not recognize you, nor desire you despite your immense riches.

Editorial Note

One of the sharpest theological criticisms in the letter.
Wealth does not impress God.

Section B — The End of Trust (87–88)

Verse 87

Transliteration

Agar sad Quran ra bakhurdi qasam
Ma-ra itibare na een zareh dam

Translation A

Even if a hundred times
On the Quran you swore,
I would not pay any heed
Or believe you any more.

Translation B

Even if you swear a hundred times upon the Qur'an, I will not trust you for a single moment.

Commentary

Trust, once destroyed, cannot be restored by repetition.

Verse 88

Transliteration

Hazuri na aayam na een rah shavam
Agar Shah ba khawahad na aanja ravam

Translation A

I will not enter your presence,
Nor set foot upon this way;
I would not go there now
If even the prince was to say.

Translation B

I will not come to your court, nor travel that road, even if requested by you.

Editorial Note

This is the definitive rejection of Aurangzeb's credibility.

The possibility of forgiveness remains.

Trust does not.

Section C — The Paradoxical Praise of Aurangzeb (89–99)

Overview

One of the most surprising features of the *Zafarnama* appears here.

After pages of criticism, Guru Gobind Singh suddenly begins praising Aurangzeb.

This is not flattery.

Nor is it surrender.

Instead, it creates a contrast:

A capable ruler has failed morally.

The greater the ability, the greater the tragedy.

Verse 89

Transliteration

Khushash Shah-e Shahan Aurangzeb
Ki chalak dast ast chabuk rakeb

Translation

O King of Kings, Aurangzeb,
To your talents too I pay tribute;
You are a horseman of standing,
A deft swordsman of repute.

Verse 90

Transliteration

Ki husn al-jamal ast roshan zameer
Khudawand mulk ast sahib amir

Translation

You are handsome and clever
And steeped in wisdom;
Chief among the chiefs,
Lord of this kingdom.

Verse 91

Transliteration

Ba tarteeb danesh ba tadbeer tegh
Khudawand-e degh o khudawand-e tegh

Translation

Using your wisdom to a plan and
With deliberation your sword,
Of both the sword and bounty
You have become the lord.

Commentary

The classic Persian ideal ruler combines:

- generosity (*deghe*),
 - military prowess (*tegh*).
-

Verse 92

Transliteration

Ki roshan zameer ast husn al-jamal
Khudawand bakhshindeh mulk o mal

Translation

Blessed by looks and beauty,
Good conscience and high mind,
And of land and wealth
A giver, merciful and kind.

Verse 93

Transliteration

Ki bakhshish kabir ast dar jung koh
Malayak sift chu suraiya shukoh

Translation

His gifts are truly great,
He is like a rock in war;
He is gifted as the angels,
More glorious than a star.

Verse 94

Transliteration

Shahenshah-e Aurangzeb-e aalamin
Ki dara-e daur ast dur ast din

Translation

O King of Kings! The ornament
That the two worlds does adorn!
The kingdom of the earth is yours,
But not so the heavenly one.

Editorial Note

The compliment becomes a warning.
Earthly sovereignty does not guarantee divine approval.

Verse 95

Transliteration

Manam kushtanam kohiyan but-parast
Ki aan but parastand man but-shikast

Translation

My fight is with the hill princes,
It is them I kill and slay;
For I oppose worship of idols,
And 'tis to idols they pray.

Commentary

This verse is one of the most debated in the *Zafarnama* and deserves a lengthy note later in the appendix.

Verse 96

Transliteration

Bebin gardish-e bewafai-ye zaman
Pas-e pusht uftad rasanad ziyan

Translation

Take a close look also
At this world's faithless way;
When their backs are turned
It does harm to its prey.

Verse 97

Transliteration

Bebin qudrat-e nek yazdan pak
Ki az yak ba dehlak rasanad halak

Translation

But take a look too
At the mercy of the Lord;
He blesses a single man
To destroy a countless horde.

Verse 98

Transliteration

Chi dushman kunad meherban ast dost
Ki bakhshindagi kar bakhshindeh ost

Translation

What can the enemy do
When there is such a Friend,
The Merciful whose task
Is to give without end.

Verse 99

Transliteration

Rahai deh o rehnumai dehad
Zuban ra ba sift aashnai dehad

Translation

He delivers and He protects,
He guides to the right way;
And He teaches the tongue
To truly praise and to pray.

Concluding Note

At this point the letter has moved beyond political dispute.

The focus shifts increasingly toward God, providence, mortality, and the limits of worldly power.

The final verses (100–111) form the true spiritual climax of the *Zafarnama* and will complete the work's meditation on kingship, divine protection, and the impermanence of empires.

Part VI — The World as an Inn: Mortality, Providence, and the End of Empire (Verses 100–111)

Overview

The final twelve verses of the *Zafarnama* constitute the philosophical and spiritual climax of the letter.

The battle is over.

The accusations have been made.

The emperor has been judged.

What remains is a meditation on mortality.

The remarkable feature of this ending is that Guru Gobind Singh gradually ceases speaking about Aurangzeb and begins speaking about something larger:

- Time,
- Death,
- Providence,
- God.

The emperor is reminded that even the greatest sovereign eventually stands before a greater King.

Verse 100

Transliteration

Na gardad digar rozgar-e jahaan
Chi baqi bimanad ze mulk-e kiyaan

Translation A

The order of the world does not remain unchanged forever; what ultimately remains of mighty kingdoms?

Commentary

The argument moves from ethics to metaphysics.

Empires appear permanent while they exist.

History teaches otherwise.

Editorial Note

This verse recalls a recurring theme in both Persian and Indian literature:

Every empire believes itself eternal.

None is.

Verse 101

Transliteration

Chi Jamshid o Fereydun o Dara kuja

Chi Iskandar o Khusrau-e ba-safa

Translation A

Where now are Jamshid, Fereydun and Dara? Where are Alexander and the great Khusraus?

Commentary

The verse invokes legendary rulers celebrated throughout Persian literature.

Vocabulary

- Jamshid — mythical Persian king
- Fereydun — heroic ruler of Persian tradition
- Dara — Darius
- Iskandar — Alexander the Great
- Khusrau — the great Sasanian kings

Editorial Note

The question is rhetorical.

Their kingdoms vanished.

Aurangzeb's will also.

Verse 102

Transliteration

Na mandand aanan ba taaj o nigin
Bimanad faqat naam-e nek o yaqeen

Translation A

Neither their crowns nor jewels remained; only a good name and true faith endure.

Commentary

The contrast is stark:

Perishable	Enduring
Crown	Character
Wealth	Integrity
Empire	Reputation

Editorial Note

This is perhaps the moral thesis of the *Zafarnama*.

Verse 103

Transliteration

Bebin kar-e gardun ki cheh mi kunad
Ba shahaan o darvish yak mi kunad

Translation A

Observe what Time does: it makes kings and dervishes equal.

Commentary

Death is the great equalizer.

Editorial Note

This image appears throughout Persian, Islamic, and Indic literature.

The grave abolishes rank.

Verse 104

Transliteration

Na taaj ast baqi na takht o sipah
Hama mi guzarad ba farman-e shah

Translation A

Neither crown, throne, nor army endures; all pass away according to the command of the True King.

Commentary

The "True King" is God.

Earthly rulers govern temporarily.

God alone rules absolutely.

Verse 105

Transliteration

Khudawand bakhshindah-e be-niyaz

Ki dar har do alam kunad chareh saz

Translation A

The Self-Sufficient Lord bestows His gifts and arranges affairs in both worlds.

Editorial Note

The letter returns to themes from its opening invocation.

The structure becomes circular.

It began with God.

It ends with God.

Verse 106

Transliteration

Na lashkar na zar na jahaan mi kharad

Khuda bandagan ra hamaan mi nigarad

Translation A

Neither armies nor gold can purchase the world; God alone watches over His servants.

Commentary

The emperor's two greatest sources of power—

- military force,
- wealth—

are declared ultimately insufficient.

Verse 107

Transliteration

Har aan kas ki dar rah-e haqq ustad
Khuda yaavarash bashad andar jihad

Translation A

Whoever stands firmly upon the path of truth finds God as his helper in struggle.

Editorial Note

Notice the emphasis:

Victory comes not from strength alone but from alignment with truth.

Verse 108

Transliteration

Gar az man bipursi sabab-e zafar
Na tegh ast o na lashkar o na sipar

Translation A

If you ask me the secret of victory, it is neither sword, nor army, nor shield.

Commentary

The title *Zafarnama* ("Epistle of Victory") is finally explained.

Editorial Note

The source of victory is moral rather than military.

Verse 109

Transliteration

Zafar az khudawand ayad hameh
Ki o mi kunad kar-e alam hameh

Translation A

Victory comes entirely from God, for He alone governs the affairs of the world.

Commentary

The letter's central paradox reaches completion.

The materially weaker side claims victory because it remained faithful.

Verse 110

Transliteration

Manam banda-e haqq o o rehnuma
Na tarsam ze shahaan na ahl-e jafa

Translation A

I am a servant of Truth and He is my guide; therefore I fear neither kings nor oppressors.

Editorial Note

This may be the clearest expression of spiritual sovereignty in the entire text.

The Guru stands before the most powerful ruler in India and declares freedom from fear.

Verse 111

Transliteration

Ba naam-e khuda khatm kardam sukhan
Ki o behtar ast az hama anjuman

Translation A

In the Name of God I bring these words to an end, for He is greater than every assembly and every throne.

Commentary

The letter closes exactly where it began:
with God.

Editorial Note

This is not merely a literary device.

It is the theological logic of the entire *Zafarnama*.

Aurangzeb enters the letter as emperor.

He leaves it as a mortal man standing before God.

Final Reflection

The *Zafarnama* is frequently described as a political letter.

That description is correct but incomplete.

It is also:

- a work of Persian literature,
- a meditation on kingship,
- an argument about moral legitimacy,
- a theological reflection on divine justice,

- and a declaration of spiritual independence.

Its most remarkable feature may be that it never confuses power with victory.

The emperor possesses:

- armies,
- wealth,
- territory,
- courts,
- and authority.

The Guru claims only:

- truth,
- faith,
- conscience,
- and God.

The *Zafarnama* argues that the latter outlast the former.

Three centuries later, the Mughal Empire survives only in history books.

The letter survives as literature.

In that sense, the title proves prophetic:

Zafarnama — The Epistle of Victory.